WASTEWATER

A toilet is not a trash can.

That is how a 130-tonne blockage in London started.

SWIPE →

LONDON, 2017

130 tonnes, 250 metres

A “fatberg” found in the sewer under Whitechapel Road.

Wet wipes, nappies, fat and oil, all set hard like concrete.

It weighed as much as 11 double-decker buses. Crews spent 3 weeks breaking it up.

THE MAIN CULPRIT

Wet wipes

When UK sewer blockages were examined, 93% of the material was wet wipes.

The UK has ~300,000 blockages a year, costing £100 million to clear.

Toilet paper made up less than 1%.

"FLUSHABLE" LABELS

Don't trust the pack

In Canada, 101 different wipes were tested. 23 were labelled "flushable".

Not one broke down enough in water.

Most contain synthetic fibres, in other words plastic.

KITCHEN MISTAKE

Hot water won't save the grease

Pour pan grease down the sink with hot water and it cools and hardens further down the pipe.

Dish soap doesn't help either. The grease still sets later.

A little each time, and over the years the pipe keeps narrowing.

THE RIGHT WAY

Protect your pipes

1. Only toilet paper goes in the toilet
2. Wipes, cotton, nappies: in the bin
3. Collect cooled grease in a lidded jar
4. Wipe the pan with paper before washing

> Easiest fix: keep a small bin next to the toilet.

What else do you want to know about water?

Tell me in the comments. The next post will be about it.

@suvyektiv